



Rocky shore life

Battered by waves and partly drying out at each low tide, a rocky shore is a dangerous place for marine life. But these coastal waters are full of food, so those animals that can adapt to life in this harsh habitat often flourish in huge numbers. As a result, a typical rocky shore is packed with dense colonies of just a few species of animal life.



IMPACT ZONE

Every wave that breaks on a rocky shore picks up loose pebbles and slams them against the rocks, and any animals that are in the way are likely to be crushed. Most of them have developed a talent for finding safe refuges in crevices, or have evolved strong armor. The thick, conical shells of these limpets are perfectly shaped to deflect the force of the waves and resist impact.



◀ LIMPETS

These specialized sea snails cling tightly to rocks at low tide, but crawl over the shore in search of food when they are underwater.

CLAMMING UP

Every few hours, the marine life on tidal shores has to cope with being exposed to the air at low tide. Many shellfish cope by closing their shells or clamping down tightly to the rocks to stop themselves from drying out, which would kill them. This also ensures that they retain a supply of water containing vital oxygen.

► MUSSELS

The hinged shells of mussels gape open when they are underwater, allowing them to feed, but are sealed shut at low tide.

